Nagaur in Rajasthan, a 16-year-old boy killed his 12-year-old cousin in a quarrel over payment tokens for online games; in Bilaspur in Chhattisgarh, 19-year-old Vasu Vishwakarma faked his own kidnapping so that he could use the ransom money to play games on PUBG. "Children these days are spending a lot of time on video games and other activities on screens," observes Sakina Qasim Zaidi, principal at the Panathur branch of Orchids–The International School in Bengaluru.

Going by a 2020 study by Birmingham University that followed gamers for six years and found that 90 per cent of them played in a manner that was not harmful to them, Neha Rai from Mumbai says she allowed her nine-year-old daughter to continue playing the Kardashian digital games on her phone. What Rai missed, however, was how the same study said that low levels of pro-social behaviour increased the risk of gamers developing addictive behaviour. Both Rai and her daughter are now undergoing counselling.

It is not just the children, though, who are addicted to gaming. The 2022 Digital Wellness Report by software company NortonLifeLock, which surveyed 1,572 city-based Indian adults, found that 60 per cent of parents spent as much time playing mobile games as their children.

Poor digital literacy of the parents is one factor fuelling gaming addiction in children. "Many parents," says Sunita George, principal of Bombay Scottish School, "lack digital awareness, and children are smart enough to convince them that they can use phones unsupervised and without restrictions." The outcome? Despite 857 porn sites being banned in India, India Child Protection Fund's 2020 study found a 95 per cent increase in porn-watching.

HOW DOES IA AFFECT YOU?

There is growing evidence to suggest that the overuse of digital devices impacts our emotional, physical and social health. The most alarming assertion is that going online can alter our brains itself. Ongoing research at Harvard University shows that children are maturing earlier from the use of phones due to the premature thinning of their cortex, the outermost layer of the brain that processes information from the five senses of the human body.

This phenomenon, which medical experts call neuroplasticity, is shown to shrink in heavy social media users, according to a 2019 research on the 'online brain' put up in pubmed. The study also found heavy social media use leading to lower transactive memory, which decides what information to store and what to forget. Externalising your memories to photographs and posts online actually prompts your brain to forget the memory because the information is already stored online.

What is alarming is that such cognitive issues have begun to set in infancy itself. "Toddlers have shown developmental delays in speech and language and even social skills as a result of digital overexposure," says Dr Himani Narula, a developmental and behavioural paediatrician and director and co-founder of Continua Kids, a child development centre in Delhi.

Digital overuse can also affect how we develop as people. Dr Piyali Bhattacharya, president of the UP chapter of the Academy of Paediatrics, says, "The screen has a direct effect on the nerves of the brain. Our nervous circuit gets rewired while looking at the screen due to the different information and situations experienced online." Increased screen time is now also being linked to eye and neck problems, obesity and even cardiac issues.

> "YOUNG PEOPLE HAVE A LESS DEVELOPED SELF-CONTROL SYSTEM, AND THEY CAN GET OBSESSED OR ADDICTED MORE QUICKLY TO REWARD BEHAVIOUR"
>
> **DR MANOJ SHARMA**
> *Psychiatrist, NIMHANS, Bengaluru*

Its physical manifestations apart, online addiction is also compromising people's social and emotional skills. "Today," says Dr Pankaj, a paediatrician at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital in Delhi, "children are getting all their entertainment on the screen itself. They do not feel the need for family or friends. Media is a one-way communication for them, it does not ask questions, only gives answers. That's why young children do not feel the need to speak or communicate offline. We get many two and three-year-olds who do not speak at all but keep making gestures. They do not feel like reading or learning anything, the comfort of cartoons and phones is enough." Zaidi observes it in schoolgoing children as well. "Kids tend to avoid time with family or share their feelings, which leads to a solitary life, devoid of emotions, keeping them away from reality," she says.

In others, social media is causing low self-esteem. The digital world's ability to broadcast the lives of millions makes many crave what they feel others have, a phenomenon captured in the acronym FOMO, or the fear of miss-